
It's Almost Swimsuit Season. American Men Are Missing Out on the Best Part.

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David Mack

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It's Almost Swimsuit Season. American Men Are Missing Out on the Best Part.

If you were on TikTok in the last few weeks, you probably saw a bunch of chatter about print—and, no, we're not talking about the newspaper. The girls and the gays spent a lot of time talking about "[catching print](#)," which is the art of looking for clues about a man's package by studying the bulge in his pants, rather than, say, whether or not he sports a "[hung smile](#)." Sure, the discourse was lewd, crude, and shamelessly objectifying in nature, but it was also evidence that there's an appetite out there for men to be a bit more groin-forward in their fashion choices. But as an Australian who has lived in the U.S. for the past 12 years, the chatter made me ask a different question: Why is it, then, that American men are still so [resistant to wearing slutty swimwear](#)?

Many Australian guys visiting a beach (as well as many [Europeans](#) and [South Americans](#)) don't think twice about donning a Speedo (which, these days, is both a famous swimwear brand and a generic term for the swimming briefs). Visiting Sydney recently, I saw men of all ages, body types, races, and sexualities rocking them. On most mornings at my local beach, men in their 80s stood around talking with one another in the warm sunshine while wearing pairs. I also spotted a dad in his late 30s walking with his wife and two kids a few hundred yards from the nearest shoreline while carrying a surfboard and wearing nothing but a floppy hat, flip-flops, and a black-and-orange Speedo. To be clear, for most of these men, Speedos aren't seen as daring or sexy, but rather practical, casual pieces that mirror their laid-back lifestyle. (In France, [wearing Speedos in public pools is even mandatory](#), as shorts that can be worn outside of the water are seen as unhygienic.)

Yet, on the few occasions when I've dared to wear a pair near Americans (who aren't gay guys like me, it must be said) people have looked at me like I'm Frankenstein's monster. In Mexico this winter, a group of American women enjoying a hot tub began whispering to each other and pointing when I strolled past in a black set. Years prior, while I was visiting Maine and swimming morning laps in the hotel pool, practically every person enjoying breakfast on the balcony put their cutlery down and guffawed.

For several years now, men's fashion observers have been speculating whether the time had finally arrived for American men to embrace swimming briefs, thanks to Speedo-sporting celebs like [Walton Goggins](#) and [Theo James](#), as well as new offerings from brands like Todd Snyder and Zara. Speedo has also reported a [significant increase in U.S. sales](#) in recent years. "Are Straight Guys Ready for Speedo Summer?" [GQ magazine](#) asked last year. "Will they show up at a beach near you?" wondered the [New York Times](#). Yet for the most part, swim briefs in the U.S. still remain the exclusive purview of gay guys and European tourists, all of which has caused the LGBTQ+ outlet [Queerty](#) to ask, "Does America have a 'Speedophobia' problem?"

Trying to make sense of this cultural difference, I called up Andy Reilly, a professor of fashion studies at the University of Hawai'i at Mānoa, who has written extensively about gender and men's fashion. He confessed to me that he hasn't worn Speedos since he was a child and rarely sees them on the beaches, despite growing up in Florida and now residing in Oahu. "They often say that the people who wear Speedos, either you're really gay or you're really straight and very comfortable with who you are," Reilly told me. "It's that middle ground where people are avoiding them."

But it's wrong to assume that Aussie guys are just more confident in their skin, according to Scott Griffiths, a psychology professor at the University of Melbourne who has studied body-image issues.

Griffiths says the rates of body dissatisfaction among Australian men is comparable to their American counterparts, meaning something else is at play. “The better explanation might be that these are just different cultural scripts,” Griffiths told me. “That is about norms and meanings, not about Australians being uniquely confident or immune to body-image pressures.”

If a Speedo seems like an especially Australian item of clothing, that’s because it is—or at least, it started as one. The [Speedo company was founded](#) at Sydney’s Bondi Beach in 1928 by a Scottish immigrant, Alexander McRae, who designed the world’s first non-wool suit for men, dubbed the “Racerback,” which [exposed the shoulders and back](#), allowing for better freedom of motion while swimming. (The style was considered daring enough that it was [banned on some Aussie beaches](#).) In 1960, Speedo employee [Peter Travis designed the classic Speedo silhouette](#) we still use today when he ignored his boss’s instructions to design something similar to Hawaiian swimming shorts and instead came up with something that was more functional to swim in. His nylon creation—positioning the briefs on the hips for more stability, instead of the waist—proved an immediate hit. (Not with beach inspectors, though, who [arrested the first man at Bondi](#) bold enough to wear a pair. The public indecency charge was later dropped, however, because none of the man’s pubic hair was showing.) Eventually, Speedos became synonymous with swimming as a professional sport, with roughly [three-quarters of Olympic medals](#) in the 1970s won by racers wearing them.





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If there's one brand that's capitalized on Speedo drifting away from its Aussie roots (the company still features a boomerang as its logo but it was acquired by a British sportswear firm in the 1990s, with manufacturing now in China), it's [Budgy Smuggler](#), a 20-year-old Sydney-based company whose loud, patterned swim briefs are now almost ubiquitous on the country's beaches. Made in Australia, Budgy Smugglers (so-called for the [Aussie slang term](#) that refers to the briefs as resembling something you'd use to stash a bird between your legs) feel as playful as the company's name, which is emblazoned across the backside of each pair, along with a logo in the shape of a budgerigar. When I visited the Budgy Smuggler distribution center on Sydney's Northern Beaches in April, CEO Adam Linforth walked me down aisle after aisle of blue storage bins that contained swimwear in more than [200 different prints](#), including flowers, pineapples, and rubber duckies, as well as some more traditionally masculine icons like beer brands and the logos of various Australian rugby teams. "I think we just give a little bit less of a fuck," Linforth told me of the Aussie taste for swim briefs. "Maybe it's an antipodean thing—living on the edge of the world. Just go for it!"





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Both Linforth and I could recall a period while we were growing up in the 1990s when American surf culture went global, exporting the style of longer board shorts to Australia and leading Speedos to be seen as dorky items your dad might wear. But just as [mullet](#)s and other vintage fashion trends have returned, so too have swim briefs. After Linforth acquired Buddy Smuggler from its founders in 2008, he initially ran operations from his bedroom as a side hustle, but booming demand means he now has about 50 full-time employees, who churn out a pair every 90 seconds to sell at stores in Australia, the U.K., and France. Turnover is roughly \$14.5 million, but just 2 percent of Linforth's sales go to the U.S., a market to which he hasn't given more attention because of Trump's tariffs and Americans' cultural reluctance to wear swim briefs. "Maybe it's a religious thing—wanting to hide because of Puritan elements," Linforth speculated to me of the American aversion. "We look at the States as a bit weird. It's just a bit unnatural to swim in shorts. We call them 'curtains of

shame.' Why would you put on pants to go swimming? You might as well wear jeans."

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Speedophobia is likely driven by a heteronormative fear of appearing feminine, said Reilly, the men's fashion expert in Hawai'i, "especially in the United States, where femininity is associated with weakness, with passiveness, or with queer communities." Men tend to determine what's masculine solely in opposition to what is feminine, he explained, meaning the Speedo is likely seen by men as being too similar to a bikini or thong. Still, Reilly believes more and more men might be open to swim briefs as younger generations, in particular, experiment with gender in fashion. Additionally, given that [the rise of gym culture](#) has led to tighter clothing for guys that better shows off their physiques or eroticizes different body parts, it may just be a matter of time until guys gravitate towards swimwear that better highlights their squat routine.



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If nothing else, I'd argue that wearing a Speedo is a signal to the world that you're relaxed, whatever your body shape or size, and that you'd prefer to put an emphasis on practicality and performance, rather than standards pushed by the media. Additionally, in a culture dominated by the [manosphere](#) and endless displays of machismo, avoiding the swim brief feels chickenshit, to use the straight-guy term. "For all the discourse and all the worshiping of the ideal phallus, and the idea that it represents masculinity, power, and strength," Reilly said, "the bathing suit for men is one area where it's hidden."

In this spirit, Linforth concedes that if he wants to ever really break into the market for American straight guys, he may need to change the Budgy Smuggler name. He cited a conversation he once had with a man at a Las Vegas hotel pool years ago wherein Linforth had to explain the self-deprecating origins of his briefs' name. "They asked, 'What does that mean that you're hiding a small bird?'" he recalled. "They said, 'Why would you joke about that? You should call it an eagle.' "

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